a resolution of the crisis: ‘bases would be dismantled under [U]nited [N]ations supervision and [C] astro would pledge not to accept offensive weapons of any kind, ever, in return for [US] pledge not to invade [C]uba.’[28]

Rusk provided Scali with a response for Feklisov that made clear the suggestion would meet with approval, but that speed was of the essence. Scali and Feklisov met again after 4.00pm (at the Statler Hotel). The American explained that the ‘highest authorities’ in the government saw ‘real possibilities’ in the proposal and recommended the idea should be pursued at the United Nations in the discussions involving Secretary General Thant.

For the White House, the proposal appeared to be linked to the arrival of a lengthy and seemingly personal letter from Khrushchev to Kennedy later that evening. This was delivered to the US Embassy in Moscow at 4.43pm Moscow Time (9.43am in Washington). The inordinate process of translation, encryption, transmission, decryption, and dissemination meant it was received in Washington in four sections between 6.00pm and 9.00pm. Preliminary reaction among Kennedy’s advisers was positive.

For many years, it was assumed that Feklisov’s approach and Khrushchev’s letter were choreographed. Roger Hilsman described the two communications as ‘a single package’.[29] In the late 1980s, however, different interpretations began to emerge. It was suggested that the KGB *Rezident* had not been acting on instructions from Moscow. Indeed, in his memoir, Feklisov admitted he said something that he had not been instructed to say: ‘I had clearly gone beyond my mission.’[30] However, these remarks concerned Soviet retaliation against West Berlin in the event of American military action against Cuba. Feklisov warned Scali that if the US attacked Cuba, the Soviet Union would invade West Berlin within twenty-four hours. Scali’s notes of the lunch make no reference to threats against West Berlin. So, the ultimatum that was not sent from the Kremlin was never delivered to the White House.

At the ‘critical oral history’ conference in Moscow in January 1989, Feklisov offered a different version of events, on which he then expanded in his memoir.[31] He said he had not outlined a proposal to resolve the missile